

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Module 8 Assignment — Automation Strategy for QA Leaders

Assignment brief: scenario, deliverables, steps and how your work is assessed.

About this assignment

Northstar's UI automation is roughly 1,800 Selenium tests that take about six hours to run and are around 25% flaky, owned by Dan alone while developers refuse to touch it — and trust in it is low. Now someone has asked you to "add 1,000 more tests" to go faster. You know that piling more UI tests onto an untrusted, slow, flaky suite is the wrong answer. You need to recommend a real automation strategy.

What you'll demonstrate

- Diagnose why the existing suite fails to build confidence
- Recommend a strategy shaped by the test pyramid, not by test count
- Decide what to automate, at which layer, and what to stop automating
- Make the case in terms of ROI, speed and trust

What to submit

- An Automation Transformation Roadmap for Northstar
- A completed Automation Assessment of the current suite
- An Automation Candidate Matrix and a Framework Decision Matrix
- An Automation ROI Worksheet supporting the recommendation

Step-by-step

1. Run the Automation Assessment on the current 1,800-test suite, diagnosing the flakiness, runtime and single-owner problems
2. Use the Automation Candidate Matrix to decide what belongs at unit, API and UI layers — and what should be removed
3. Directly address the "add 1,000 more" request and explain why more UI tests is the wrong move
4. Use the Framework Decision Matrix and ROI Worksheet to justify the direction, including shifting ownership toward developers

5. Sequence the change as a roadmap — stabilise, rebalance toward the pyramid, then grow trust — with realistic milestones

Submission format

Submit as a PDF or DOCX combining the assessment, the matrices, the ROI case and the roadmap.

How your work is assessed

If a QA lead reviewed this, they would look for:

- A diagnosis that gets at why the suite is untrusted, not just that it is
- A strategy driven by the test pyramid and risk, not by adding UI tests
- An explicit, well-argued response to the "add 1,000 more" request
- Ownership addressed — moving away from a single, isolated maintainer
- An ROI case a cost-conscious executive would accept

Templates & resources to use

- Automation Assessment — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Automation Candidate Matrix — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Automation Framework Decision Matrix — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Automation ROI Worksheet — find it in the Resource Vault.
- Automation Roadmap — find it in the Resource Vault.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Nobody trusts a suite that fails 25% of the time for no reason. Fix trust before you add volume — a smaller, reliable, developer-owned suite beats three thousand flaky UI tests every release.